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Interviews

Interviews are a qualitative research method used to explore users’ needs, motivations, experiences, and expectations through structured or semi-structured conversations.

Phase: **User Research** Effort level: **Medium**

Article

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Why interviews are important in research-driven projects

The development of research-driven technologies is commonly guided by scientific objectives and experimental results. While this approach ensures technical rigor, it may leave questions about user needs, everyday contexts, and practical application insufficiently explored.

Interviews help make these assumptions explicit. By speaking directly with intended users or stakeholders, research teams can:

- **Identify unmet needs and pain points early**
- **Understand contextual factors that influence technology use**
- **Reduce the risk of developing solutions that are technically valid but practically unusable**

When integrated early, interviews support more informed research questions, clearer problem framing, and smoother transitions from laboratory research to real-world application.

Types of interviews

Different interview formats serve different research goals. Selecting the appropriate type helps ensure that insights are relevant and reliable.

Structured interviews

Interviews based on a fixed set of predefined questions, asked in the same order to all participants.

Use when:

- **You need consistency across participants**
- **Comparing responses is important**
- **Research questions are clearly defined**

Avoid when:

- **You are still exploring an open problem**
- **Flexibility and follow-up questions are needed**

Typical outcomes:

- **Comparable responses**
- **Clear themes aligned with predefined topics**

Semi-structured interviews

Most used format in UX research

Interviews guided by a set of core questions, with flexibility to explore emerging topics during the conversation.

Use when:

- **You want to explore user needs while maintaining focus**
- **Research questions are defined but open to refinement**
- **Contextual understanding is important**

Avoid when:

- **Strict comparability is required**
- **Time is extremely limited**

Typical outcomes:

- **Rich qualitative insights**
- **Emergent themes and unexpected findings**

Unstructured interviews

Open conversations with minimal predefined structure, allowing participants to guide the discussion.

Use when

- **The problem space is largely unknown**
- **Early exploration is the main goal**
- **Building deep contextual understanding**

Avoid when

- **You need focused answers**
- **Participants are not comfortable with open discussion**

Typical outcomes

- **Broad insights**
- **High variability across interviews**

Choosing the right interview type

The choice of interview type should reflect the research goal, not personal preference.

Quick guidance

- Exploring a new problem → Unstructured or semi-structured
- Refining assumptions → Semi-structured
- Validating specific topics → Structured

In research-driven projects, semi-structured interviews often offer the best balance between flexibility and rigor.

Sections

Types of interviews

Preparing for interviews

Conducting the interview

After the interview

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Did this help you in your project?



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